IMPLICATIONS OF THE IDEAS

These three ideas illustrate the different assumptions that underlie the **environmental policy debate** of our times, across the world. They reflect different views towards humanity in the natural world, and of its obligations to future generations as well as other species.

Present U.S. policy is most closely approximated by the environmental protection paradigm, while many environmental groups espouse the eco-development perspective. Resource management is viewed by many policymakers as the most practical approach toward reconciling economic activity and environmental quality.

These ideas also suggest different criteria for defining green technologies. In the environmental protection view, a specific technology or product design may be considered green if it results in less waste generation than a previous technology. The same design may be rejected from the eco-development perspective because it uses non-renewable materials that are not recycled and do not biodegrade.

Thus, green technology development within each succeeding 'views' involves satisfying a correspondingly broader set of criteria for compatibility with the natural environment.[26]

HOLISTIC THINKING – NEED OF THE TIME

Whatever be the 'idea' adopted by society, technological innovation will likely have the greatest environmental benefit if it is used to address problems in a holistic manner. From an environmental perspective, it is simplistic to view technologies or products in isolation from the production and consumption systems in which they function. Bigger environmental gains lie in changing the overall systems in which technologies or products are manufactured, used, and disposed, rather than in modifying technological components or changing the composition of products itself.

Technological solutions are usually context dependent, for example, 'reformulated' gasoline could be considered to be 'greener' than current